

Congress has a traditional votebank while the NCP has no vote-base. As a result, our votes get transferred to them in constituencies where we are not contesting due to seat-sharing."

Less than a month after the results, the NCP is busy battling crises on all fronts. Be it Padamsinh's arrest for his alleged involvement in the murder of Congress leader Pawanraje Nimbalkar or the role of the Home Ministry during the 26/11 attacks, the

walls are closing in on the party from all sides. With their tally coming down to seven MPs in Maharashtra, the NCP needs the Congress more than ever. No wonder Pawar-baiters like Deshmukh are pushing their party to dump the NCP in the assembly elections or else the Congress will have to pay for their partner's non-performance. Says Sanjay Dutt, general secretary, Maharashtra Congress: "Congress leaders will kick

help Congress rebel Ajit Ghorpade. Nitin Gadkari, BJP chief in Maharashtra, confirms: "We withdrew our candidate to give a tough fight to the Congress. There was no deal with the NCP but it just happened that Jayant supported Ghorpade over Pratik." In order to cut the NCP to size, the Congress has included Pratik to consolidate the Congress in western Maharashtra. With over 23 per cent of the Maratha vote, the Congress has invested in Deshmukh a cabinet portfolio, thereby crowning him their tallest Maratha. The upgradation of Prithviraj Chavan is another signal sent through western Maharashtra, that it pays to be with the Congress.

Since then the story has moved on. The Congress, elated at the downfall of the NCP, is now worried about the assembly polls. Having defeated the party in the Lok Sabha elections, local Congress leaders are now baying for its blood. Says Pratik, whose grandfather was overthrown by Sharad Pawar to become the youngest chief minister in 1978: "The workers at the grassroots level are really upset as at the local level we are opponents and at the national level, they have to work for the NCP's candidates. The central leadership will have to decide how they want to contest this time as local leaders and workers have ambitions for their own party." While the Congress high command isn't in a mood to split with the NCP yet, it may not be able to ignore its partner's betrayal. For instance, in Nandurbar, the Congress put up Manikrao Gavit, a nine-time MP, but the NCP supported Samajwadi Party's Sharad Gavit.

While the NCP was busy working against its partner during elections, its parochial attitude towards the Marathas reduced the party's appeal with the electorate. The NCP Vice-President, Vinayak Mete, raised the issue of Maratha reservation in the state last year, a decision that has backfired. At the NCP's own review meetings, there has been open criticism that the decision to propagate Maratha reservation has polarised non-Maratha groups.



PTI

JAYANT PATIL

PORTFOLIO Home

SCORE CARD Left the Finance Ministry with a debt of Rs 1,85,801 crore. As home

minister, failed to appoint a head of Anti-Terrorism Squad for six months. The Home Department has misplaced the files on the purchase of inferior-quality bulletproof jackets.

WORK IN PROGRESS Force One, a commando unit due in six months, is still under training. Police reforms have not been implemented for over 10 years.

off the *sampark abhiyaan* tour to boost the morale of the workers."

The NCP's back-stabbing has angered Congress leaders in the state, who are determined to convey their angst to the high command. Its leadership has used the Lok Sabha elections to settle personal scores. The legacy of former Maharashtra chief minister Vasantdada Patil's rivalry with Sharad Pawar and Congress leader Rajarambapu Patil is being carried forward not only by Pawar but also by state Home Minister Jayant Patil, who worked against Vasantdada's grandson Pratik Patil in Sangli. Congressmen allege that Pawar personally asked the BJP to withdraw its candidate to